

Familiar Outsiders Abroad

Relational Racialization in the Romani Atlantic World

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INTRODUCTION

Romani people significantly and fundamentally shaped, and were shaped by, transatlantic ethno-racial projects between the fifteenth and nineteenth centuries. They were considered, and considered themselves, in relation to the evolving web of beliefs that bound people from four continents together and that prompted new concepts and categories transformative to the lives of all Atlantic inhabitants. Their physical and ideological presence as familiar outsiders made them a referent and a template for non-Romani Europeans anxious to comprehend and control less-familiar outsiders being racially generated and sorted through colonial encounters and administration. At the same time, Romani people also made choices informed by a racial matrix within which they maneuvered. Ideological exchanges and personal interactions formed conceptions of transatlantic difference with Romani people playing a crucial part in these processes.

This chapter exposes the ideological work that made impressions held about Romani people possible for non-Romani Europeans, while simultaneously considering how Romani people participated in the construction of imperial racial regimes. It is an addition to an emerging literature in Critical Romani Studies that theorizes how antigypsyism has become one stabilizing dimension of whiteness as well as a crucial component of global racializing practices in general.¹ By stretching the frame to include

¹ Margareta Matache, *The Permanence of Anti-Roma Racism: (Un)uttered Sentences* (Routledge, 2026); Lesia Pahulich, "Racialization of Roma, European Modernity, and the Entanglement of Empires," *Critical Romani Studies* 8, no. 1 (2025): 40–61, <https://doi.org/10.29098/crs.v8i1.208>; Jelena Savić, "Gadjo Supremacy and Gadjo Privileges,"

European colonies and colonized subjects, it complicates recent scholarship that describes how Europeans, through analogous comparisons, invented “Gypsies” while inventing European modernity.² Turning Romani people into foreign locals in Europe would not have happened as it did, however, without the nearly simultaneous encounters between Europeans and Indigenous Americans, and the accompanying invention of “Indians” in European thought. The chapter explains this by drawing on Noémie Ndiaye’s ideas of “racial scripts” as trans-imperial “metaphorical strains” that “were not simply ornamental” but rather “resources” that generated racial categories and organized racial power relations. By producing ideas about one group alongside other groups and oneself, or scripting race relationally, a multidimensional matrix of conceptions and power relations encompassed all. And as matrices are, in another sense, the substances within which reproduction occurs, Romani-inflected racial scripts multiplied, spread and solidified. This explains the constancy of the form across time, space and circumstance.³

To show this, I augment Patricia Galletti’s ideas about how “under the imperial gaze, the *indios* and the Gitanos were part of the same repertoire of otherness,” but I move beyond seeing Romani signifiers as a unit of otherness in and of themselves.⁴ I also move beyond Tamar Herzog’s juxtaposition of the exclusions from full community membership that African, Romani and Indigenous actors faced as local yet foreign within European polities. By relating these ideas, categories, policies and

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² Klaus-Michael Bogdal, *Europe and the Roma: A History of Fascination and Fear*, trans. Jefferson Chase (Penguin, 2023).

³ Noémie Ndiaye, *Scripts of Blackness: Early Modern Performance Culture and the Making of Race* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2022), 3–8; Natalia Molina, “The Power of Racial Scripts: What the History of Mexican Immigration to the United States Teaches Us about Relational Notions of Race,” *Latino Studies* 8, no. 2 (2010): 156–175, <https://doi.org/10.1057/lst.2010.20>; Natalia Molina, Daniel Martinez HoSang and Ramón A. Gutiérrez, eds., *Relational Formations of Race: Theory, Method, and Practice* (University of California Press, 2019); Laura Tabili, “Race Is a Relationship, and Not a Thing,” *Journal of Social History* 37, no. 1 (2003): 125–130, <https://dx.doi.org/10.1353/jsh.2003.0162>.

⁴ Patricia Galletti, “Los Gitanos como Otro y como Horizonte de Otridad en la Hispanoamérica Colonial (S. XV a XIX),” *International Journal of Roma Studies* 3, no. 2 (2021): 119, <https://doi.org/10.17583/ijrs.8527>.

experiences within a transatlantic frame the linkages between powerful new types of belonging and estrangement surface.⁵ This chapter also differs from prior scholarship that explores images of Romani people,⁶ Native Americans,⁷ or African and African-descended people⁸ in the minds of non-Romani, imperialist, whites thinking about themselves through thinking about another. Such scholarship usually treats in isolation a people being depowered through the descriptive and often degrading words of those with imperial or national aims and conceals the more complex situation at work. Instead, by drawing on notions of relational racialization as expressed and constructed through racial scripts, I expose and track an ideological layer that lightly, but tightly, engulfed all Atlantic subjects.

Race did not just emerge out of new transatlantic encounters, nor was it a logical consequence of even earlier European experiences with those outside Europe. Rather, Romani people's fifteenth-century arrival to Western Europe⁹ colored the way non-Romani Europeans made sense of other new people they encountered and who also looked and acted in

⁵ Tamar Herzog, "Indigenous Reducciones and Spanish Resettlement: Placing Colonial and European History in Dialogue," *Ler História* 72 (2018): 9–30, <https://doi.org/10.4000/lerhistoria.3146>; Tamar Herzog, "Beyond Race: Exclusion in Early Modern Spain and Spanish America," in *Race and Blood in the Iberian World*, ed. Max S. Hering Torres, María Elena Martínez and David Nirenberg (LIT Verlag, 2012), 151–67. For an English equivalent, see David Cressy, *Gypsies: An English History* (Oxford University Press, 2018), 89.

⁶ Dalen Wakeley-Smith, "'The One Primitive People Who Contact with Civilization has Failed to Exterminate': New York and 'Gypsy' Madness in the 1920s," *Journal of American Ethnic History* 43, no. 1 (2023): 67–87, <https://doi.org/10.5406/19364695.43.1.03>; Jodie Matthews, *The Gypsy Woman: Representations in Literature and Visual Culture* (Bloomsbury, 2018); Sarah Houghton-Walker, *Representations of the Gypsy in the Romantic Period* (Oxford University Press, 2014); Deborah Epstein Nord, *Gypsies and the British Imagination, 1807–1930* (Columbia University Press, 2006); Lou Charnon-Deutsch, *The Spanish Gypsy: The History of a European Obsession* (Pennsylvania State University Press, 2004).

⁷ Kate Flint, *The Transatlantic Indian: 1776–1930* (Princeton University Press, 2009); Sherry L. Smith, *Reimagining Indians: Native Americans through Anglo Eyes, 1880–1940* (Oxford University Press, 2000); Philip J. Deloria, *Playing Indian* (Yale University Press, 1998).

⁸ Alejandro de la Fuente and Ariela J. Gross, *Becoming Free, Becoming Black: Race, Freedom, and Law in Cuba, Virginia, and Louisiana* (Cambridge University Press, 2020); Rana A. Hogarth, *Medicalizing Blackness: Making Racial Difference in the Atlantic World, 1780–1840* (University of North Carolina Press, 2017); Ibram X. Kendi, *Stamped from the Beginning: The Definitive History of Racist Ideas in America* (Nation, 2016).

⁹ Cressy, *Gypsies*, 5–10.

unexpected ways. That Romani people had arrived in many European places just as new transatlantic sojourns started unfolding meant that the ontological practices developed in response to Romani people were just settling into the minds of Europeans as European westward explorations began. As a result, European views of Romani people, Native Americans, Africans and themselves as Europeans (and eventually as white) co-developed; precisely because of the near synchronous exposures, the scripts attached to each category of people remained dynamic and reiteratively overlay scripts about the others. Thus, it is unsurprising that the demarcations that had been most often applied to recently arrived Romani people to Europe – those related to physiognomy, mobility, insularity and respectability – remained conceptually prevalent during European transatlantic considerations of others and self. These were the symbolic pieces eventually put to racializing work.

Romani arrivals to Western Europe had primed Europeans, especially once abroad, to notice just such criteria when encountering new strangers. This heightened awareness for particular registers of difference led to the co-construction of race via considerations of European, Native American, African and Romani people. Though this occurred unevenly across time, place and purpose, it intensified once the Atlantic horizon became more central to European lives. The internal Other, however, was not merely replaced with the external Other, rather they were commingled, along with the conjoiner, to relationally create race. Components of this “mingledness” could then be called upon as needed during a particular historical moment in service of a specific purpose.

Though the transatlantic relational racialization of Romani and other people always remained historically embedded, the script’s content incorporated a timelessness¹⁰ that strengthened the permanency of race. This allowed racialized content to transcend generations. Romani tropes reified as their usefulness grew, which occurred as Europeans recognized the significance and scale of new transatlantic possibilities. Enlightenment notions of progress fed the anxiety of colonizers looking for evidence of their own superiority over the supposed primitiveness of others they felt bound to control and dominate. Thus, the very historical process of early modern transatlantic relational racialization created the timeless “Gypsy” that is still very much alive today. This trope stabilized through its continued contrast with other racialized stock characters, including the

¹⁰ Katie Trumpener, “The Time of the Gypsies: A ‘People without History’ in the Narratives of the West,” *Critical Inquiry* 18, no. 4 (1992): 843–84, <https://doi.org/10.1086/448659>.

civilized European. This chapter briefly describes and analyzes just some of these historical moments.

Non-Romani Europeans used Romani people as a referent when attempting to understand even less-familiar people they encountered during colonization. This practice remained eerily consistent across time, place and people. We might even speak of a metaphorical translucent “Gypsy veil” that covered and tangled together early modern transatlantic actors and from within which racial thinking emerged. Illustrative examples from behind this veil stretch from the sixteenth through nineteenth centuries, and are drawn from Portuguese, Spanish, French and English American spaces, though authors hailed from and moved through an even broader geography. Several people and policies even had Central European connections. That the authors of most sources were either transatlantic travelers or engaged in transatlantic conversations reveals a mobile ideology active across time and space.

IBERIAN ATLANTIC

The earliest known example of a European engaging with the Americas through the “Gypsy veil” comes from two 1501 letters written by the Venetian ambassador to Portugal, Pietro Pasqualigo. In October of that year, over fifty men, women and children, Natives of today’s Greenland or Newfoundland and some of the first Indigenous Americans to arrive in Europe, landed in Lisbon. These kidnapped families were then put on display. The week after their arrival Pasqualigo attempted a description: “They are of like colour, figure, stature, and aspect, and bear the greatest resemblance to the *cingani*.” This first documented instance of a European linking Romani people with Indigenous Americans soon spread via a Latin translation made the following year and a French one in 1522. Over the centuries, Pasqualigo’s letters were translated and reprinted many times ensuring broad exposure to his words. To him, physical appearance prompted the “resemblance,” and though other aspects would soon emerge, physiognomy remained a coherent thread. Likewise, this instance arose from a violent context: coercion and power accompanied transatlantic relational racialization from the start.¹¹

¹¹ Donald Weinstein, *Ambassador from Venice: Pietro Pasqualigo in Lisbon, 1501* (University of Minnesota Press, 1960), 73, 103n24; *A Memoir of Sebastian Cabot; with a Review of the History of Maritime Discovery* (Philadelphia, 1831), 236; *The Journal of Christopher Columbus*, trans. Clements R. Markham (London, 1893), 235–38. It is

About fifty years later, José Anchieta, the Canarian Jesuit missionary to the Portuguese colony of Brazil, attempted to familiarize his readers with the Native people there through relational considerations. After describing Indigenous Brazilians as lacking cities, laws or councils, he recognized them as a nation divided into many smaller nations, most of whom wandered. From these points, he continued:

You may recognize some similarities in the vagabond race of men who brag that they are descended from the dregs of the Egyptians . . . whom we call *Zingaros* in Europe: [and] who also seem to be related by their bronze color to Brazilians, although the *Zingari* are prone to theft, which the Brazilians abhor. The *Zingari* avoid wars, which consume the Brazilians. They wear our clothes and carry out some small trades by which they earn money. The Brazilians are naked, inert, and hostile to labor, with no other industry than hunting and fishing.

Here, while skin color remains, he further explains each group vis-à-vis the other and himself via contrasting behavioral traits. Assumptions of his own civility and the savagery of the others can be implied by his recounting levels of honesty, violence, mobility, motivation and civic attachment.¹² Today a Catholic saint, Anchieta is considered a founder of both São Paulo and Rio de Janeiro. His linguistic, ethnographic and literary writings circulated broadly in both manuscript and print form through Jesuit networks. It was common for later Jesuits to pull from former ones in ethnographic typologies, especially of the Americas. This has prompted one historian to note their important role in creating “a distinct ontological category of ‘Indian.’” But this ontological “Indian” came to exist, at least partially, through an ontological “Gypsy.”¹³

probably not a coincidence that a person from Venice would initiate the first relational reference coming out of Western Europe. Though only documented as residing in Portugal from the 1520s, Romani people lived in Venetian towns by at least 1444. George C. Soulis, “The Gypsies in the Byzantine Empire and the Balkans in the Late Middle Ages,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 15 (1961): 152. For the first references to Romani people in Portugal, see Francisco Mangas, “A Outra Minoria: Uma história dos Ciganos portugueses durante a Época Moderna” (PhD diss., University of Porto, 2024), 55–56, 68, 229–30.

¹² Sebastiano Beretario, *Iosephi Anchietae Societatis Iesv Sacerdotis in Brasilia Defuncti Vita* (1617), 39; A similar reference from 1557 explains the blanketed dress of the Toalli women from Florida as being “after the manner of the Ciganos.” A Gentleman of Elvas, *The True Relation of the Hardships Suffered by Governor Hernando de Soto*, trans. and ed. James Robertson (Florida State Historical Society, 1932), 118.

¹³ Gabriel Martínez-Serna, “Procurators and the Making of the Jesuits’ Atlantic Network,” in *Soundings in Atlantic History: Latent Structures and Intellectual Currents, 1530–1830*, ed. Bernard Bailyn and Patricia L. Denault (Harvard University Press, 2009), 196.

This linkage appears again in a 1554 chronicle left by the German explorer, Ulrico Schmidl, who had traveled with the expedition that founded Buenos Aires two decades prior. Schmidl recalled his first encounters with the Indigenous Querandi people through the lens of his assumptions about Romani people in the German lands. Written to satisfy a public curious about the Americas, Schmidl undoubtedly strove to make legible a place few Europeans could imagine, much less experience. Though brief, his comparison suggests that both Romani and Querandi peoples' mobility and perception as outsiders, even within their respective homelands, functioned similarly enough to illuminate his German-speaking audience about both others and self. As he explained it, the Querandi "have no place of their own in the country; they roam the earth just like the *Zigeuner* here in German countries."¹⁴ Schmidl tethered the two groups together in a familiarizing practice, while also tethering them both to himself in contrast – white Europeans did not "roam." Both this practice and its ideological contents would endure.

The "Gypsy veil" Schmidl alerts us to, unfurled further to encompass other people and situations. The farming practices of settler colonists near São Paulo troubled royal authorities enough in the 1640s that they rhetorically explained these agricultural methods relationally under the influence of a Romani-infused perception. Utilizing slash and burn husbandry techniques, which had been learned from local Indigenous farmers, meant that colonial agriculturalists would "*se azingarem*," or move about like Ciganos. This concerned bureaucrats desirous of settled populations and echoed complaints about Portuguese Romani people, whose mobility at this time, somewhat ironically, often resulted in their banishment to Indigenous American homelands. To be appropriately Portuguese in Brazil meant rejecting behaviors ascribed in common to Indigenous and Romani people, illustrating how the generation of racialized ideas about one group occurred alongside others and self.¹⁵

¹⁴ Ulrico Schmidl, *Derrotero y viaje a España y las Indias, 1534–1554*, trans. Edmundo Wernicke (Universidad Nacional de Litoral, 1938), 44. The original manuscript has been digitized by the Württemberg State Library, https://digital.wlb-stuttgart.de/index.php?id=6&tx_dlf%5Bid%5D=16324&tx_dlf%5Bpage%5D=1.

¹⁵ *Actas da Camara da Villa de S. Paulo, 1640–1652* (Archivo Municipal, 1915), 5:365; John M. Monteiro, *Blacks of the Land: Indian Slavery, Settler Society, and the Portuguese Colonial Enterprise in South America*, trans. and ed. James Woodard and Barbara Weinstein (Cambridge University Press, 2018), 98; Martin Fotta, "The Figure of the Gypsy (*Cigano*) as a Signpost for Crises of the Social Hierarchy (Bahia, 1590s–1900s)," *International Review of Social History* 65, no. 2 (2019): 8–10, <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0020859019000713>.

In Spain, this veil expressed itself in more practical ways. Considerations of how to manage Romani people there often did so alongside Indigenous American subjects. The earliest writings on the matter aimed to keep the two groups apart, whereas later ones suggested combining the two together. No matter which outcome was pursued, considering each together intensified the linkages they were imagined sharing. From 1581, Gitanos were barred from immigrating to Spanish America on the grounds that they were harmful to attempts to convert the Native people whose “natural simplicity” made them gullible victims to Gitano “tricks.”¹⁶ When reconsidering the potential to deport Gitanos to the Americas in the mid-eighteenth century, similar concerns were raised. A 1749 report submitted to Ferdinand VI included among the disadvantages of doing so, “that if they live badly in Spain, in the Indies they will live worse and will pervert the poor Indians.”¹⁷

Other Spanish thinkers suggested an alternative possibility that presumably seemed logical considering the closeness of Romani people and Indigenous Americans in their minds. In conversations about what to do with those interred as part of the “Great Round-Up,” a coordinated attempt begun in 1749 to arrest and then eliminate every Gitano in Spain, the statesman and reformer Pedro Rodríguez de Campomanes suggested repealing the 1581 decree to allow for the removal of Gitano children and single women to American colonies. The latter were to marry Indigenous men and thus facilitate the disappearance of Spanish Gitanos; presumably these “Indians” might vanish as such as well. Other proposals encouraged transporting young Romani boys and girls to sparsely inhabited islands and colonies and marrying them to locals. This proposal imaginatively assumed that all parties would recognize the benefit of this plan, since Gitanos would never “be able to pass for Spanish” and since none would want “to retain the odious name of Gitanos.” Though never enacted, later plans reiterated separating Romani women and men geographically and sexually. Women should be sent to the American continent to marry “Indians, Mestizos, or creoles,” and men to colonial islands to marry “island women.” The goal was the wholesale destruction of Romani people via population control measures – policing their reproductive choices in the context of imperial

¹⁶ Tamar Herzog, *Defining Nations: Immigrants and Citizens in Early Modern Spain and Spanish America* (Yale University Press, 2003), 129, 249n36.

¹⁷ Antonio Gómez Alfaro, Elisa María Lopes da Costa and Sharon Sillers Floate, *Deportaciones de Gitanos* (Centre de recherches tsiganes, 1999), 19.

Atlantic possibilities – that required an Indigenous population into which they might disappear.¹⁸ Though there was never any explicit mention of what this would mean for the Indigenous host communities, one can presume that the spread of “Spanishness,” even through a corrupted Romani version of it, might also be seen as good for the empire. The web of beliefs that bound non-Romani and Romani Spaniards and Indigenous Americans together simultaneously expressed and generated racialized content, policy and experiences. Though Atlantic in origin, such dynamics spread. The lessons from such racial governance in Spanish America were carried to Central Europe through the mechanisms of Habsburg rule.¹⁹

That Gitanos and Indigenous Americans engaged with each other in both the Americas and Europe suggests their role in the creation of this ideological proximity that then impacted some of their choices. In just one example, from 1755, Manuel Ximénez appealed a prison sentence of forced labor that had been issued for breaking one of the numerous anti-Gitano decrees then active in Spain. He appealed on the grounds that his parents were not Gitanos, but Natives of Cuba. Ximénez believed that the confusion about his ancestry stemmed from his wife, María Francisca, being “*de nación Gitana*,” which had led others to assume his Gitano rather than “Indio” ancestry.²⁰ One’s reputation was often relied upon by Iberian and colonial administrators, who with anti-Gitano restrictions in place were then confronted with identifying and sorting Romani people from everyone else. One Buenos Aires judge thus concluded “that it was impossible to determine with certainty who was a Gitano and who was not,” although in Spain many people believed in clear signs that gave individuals the appearance of Gitanos.²¹

That Native Americans and Romani people socialized together led to confusion about the ancestry of individuals and where they should be placed within imperial Atlantic typographies. As a result, non-Romani people were often caught up by decrees intended to control Spanish

¹⁸ Gómez Alfaro, et al., *Deportaciones de Gitanos*, 27–33; Antonio Gómez Alfaro, *The Great Gypsy Round-Up: Spain, the General Imprisonment of Gypsies in 1749* (University of Hertfordshire Press, 1993).

¹⁹ William O’Reilly, “*Divide et impera*: Race, Ethnicity, and Administration in Early 18th-Century Habsburg Hungary,” in *Racial Discrimination and Ethnicity in European History*, ed. Gudmundur Hálfðánarson and Anne Katherine Isaacs (Edizioni Plus, 2003): 77–100.

²⁰ Gómez Alfaro, et al., *Deportaciones de Gitanos*, 30.

²¹ Herzog, *Defining Nations*, 133.

Gitanos, evidencing the convolution of perceived racial content and categories. The blacksmith Bartolomé Fernández, for example, had been ordered to leave Iznájar in 1746 and move to Córdoba, a city authorized for Gitano residences. A decree of that year demanded that Romani people relocate to one of forty-one approved towns across mainland Spain. Fernández appealed this decision on the grounds that he was “*de nación Indiana*.” His blacksmithing trade, one traditional for Gitanos to practice and recently made illegal for them, could have made him suspect, especially if he looked a certain way or socialized among certain people. Whatever the cause, his claimed identity was verified by the authorities, and he was allowed to remain in his hometown. Yet his experience illustrates that the *process* of constructing race disrupted lives just as readily as any reified notion of race.²²

Further evidence from the Spanish Atlantic illustrates the texture of this process. When the Polish Jesuit Florian Paucke noted of his time with the Moquit people in today’s Paraguay during the mid-eighteenth century that “the color of the body and face of these Indians is the same as that seen in the *Zigeuner*” he wove and spread the “Gypsy veil.” Paucke descriptively continued, “one of these boys was of white appearance and color, not like the others with a *Zigeuner* complexion . . . [Others] have a white-yellow face and somewhat reddish cheeks, others are light-brown or dark-fleshed, others dark-brown, others like the *Zigeuner* in Hungary.”²³ Here again the network of Jesuit priests played a role in the circulation of these physiognomic ideas.

Two other Jesuits, writing from Spanish South America, one from Río de la Plata and another from northern Mexico, related the mobility of certain tribal groups to Gitanos in Spain, thus securing the assumption that Spaniards should not be mobile. “The Jobas are a *nación muy Gitana*, an untamed and wandering people. Although there are a number of pueblos where they can come and live, most of them migrate like Gitanos from canyon to canyon,” noted Joseph Roldán in 1762.²⁴ Similarly, Manuel Moreno Alonso described a Puerto Rican stopover during his 1747 journey between Cadiz and Veracruz by noting how

²² Herzog, *Defining Nations*, 133; Gómez Alfaro, et al., *Deportaciones de Gitanos*, 30; Richard Pym, *The Gypsies of Early Modern Spain* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2007), 145–47.

²³ Florian Paucke, *Zuwettler Codex 420*, ed. Etta Becker-Donner (Wilhelm Braumuller University, 1959), I:183, 239, 303 and II:452.

²⁴ Galletti, “Los Gitanos como Otro,” 121–22; Cynthia Radding, *Wandering Peoples: Colonialism, Ethnic Spaces, and Ecological Frontiers in Northwestern Mexico, 1700–1850* (Duke University Press, 1997), 148.

the Indigenous people, called “Jíbaros,” struck him with their “mulatto-like” skin and the women’s “Gitano-like” appearance.²⁵ Physiognomy and mobility, in these examples, helped these Spanish men make sense of Indigenous Americans through conceptions they held about others and themselves. Comprehending through racial scripts generated and entrenched a racial matrix throughout the Iberian Atlantic world and beyond.

FRENCH ATLANTIC

The racial matrix woven within the Iberian Atlantic tangled with analogous assumptions and experiences from the French Atlantic world. French Romani people, called *Bohémiens* during the early modern era, served as a racial reference for non-*Bohémien* French colonizers within an ideological sphere that Romani people’s actions helped entwine. In 1727, the Jesuit Paul Poisson denigratingly compared the French voyageurs who worked as traders among the tribes, to both Indigenous and Romani people. He notes: “To see these men, clad with but one garment, more sunburnt and more swarthy than the Savages – stretched upon the sand or squatting like monkeys, devouring what they hold in their hand – one does not know whether they are in a company of *Bohémiens*, or of people holding a witches revel.”²⁶ His comment reveals the fear of French men declining into “savagery” as well as the relational perspective at work. Poisson’s reference to dark skin color, lazy and animalistic postures, and clothing all imply an attempt to position *Bohémiens*, Native people and white voyageurs into his racializing worldview vis-à-vis each other. He reveals a perceived closeness between *Bohémiens* and non-white people, as well as his assumptions about what it meant to be French and white. Much later, another French traveler exemplified this proximity when he, with some uncertainty, described the musicians at an 1802 New Orleans carnival ball as being “*Bohemes* or people of color strumming heavily on their violins.”²⁷

²⁵ Manuel Moreno Alonso, “De Cadiz a Veracruz en 1745,” *Historiografía y bibliografía Americanistas* 27 (1983): 18, 32; Francisco A. Scarano, “The Jíbaro Masquerade and the Subaltern Politics of Creole Identity Formation in Puerto Rico, 1745–1823,” *American Historical Review* 101, no. 5 (1996): 1415, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2170177>.

²⁶ “Lettre au P.re Paul du Poisson; aux Akensas, October 3, 1727,” in *The Jesuit Relations and Allied Documents*, ed. Reuben Gold Thwaites (Cleveland, 1900), 67:314–15.

²⁷ Pierre-Louis Berquin-Duvallon, *Vue de la colonie Espagnole du Mississipi, ou des provinces de Louisiane et Floride Occidentale, en l’année 1802* (Paris, 1803), 32.

This closeness bears out within many eighteenth-century Louisiana sources. Some French colonial *Bohémiens*, many from families deported in 1720, did in fact choose to make connections with Black and Indigenous people. The *Bohémienne* woman Cécile Christophe Varangue, born soon after her mother's transportation, and her daughters François and Babé socialized and formed intimate, familial and professional relationships with Indigenous men. At least one Anglo-Romani woman conducted herself similarly with an African man in Virginia at the end of the prior century.²⁸ These connections caught the attention of authorities working to regulate race in both colonies. In 1772, a Louisiana commandant recommended the removal of a young Indigenous girl from Varangue's care; he also supported her and her daughter Babé's imprisonment for not marrying in ways suitable to the local religious authorities. A male relative of these women, one M. Bonnité, was recommended for deportation to France for putting "the Indians at risk of becoming unruly." Administrative complaints against these *Bohémiens* involved their relationships with tribal people, evidencing both the social choices they made as well as the concerns these choices provoked.²⁹ Colonial agents desirous of enhancing their own racialized power might try to manipulate the racial matrix by separating those who contemporary racial logics had placed close together. Though the results were mixed, such official action undoubtedly solidified and entrenched the hierarchy of racial scripts.

Other evidence proves these women's choices were not unique. Two Louisiana Romani women married free men of color – one under French rule in 1725 and the other under Spanish rule in 1779. This 1725 marriage between Marie Jacqueline Gaspart "*Bohemian*" and Jean Baptiste Raphael "*nègre libre*" was the first officially sanctioned interracial marriage in the colony. The special permission needed to approve this marriage was likely only granted because Gaspart was *Bohémien*. There are no known examples of any non-*Bohémien* French white women (either officially or by custom) marrying an Indigenous or African-descended man throughout the early French Atlantic. Regulating sex, especially

²⁸ Ann Ostendorf, "Louisiana Bohémiens: Community, Race, and Empire," *Early American Studies: An Interdisciplinary Journal* 19, no. 4 (2021): 686, <https://doi.org/10.1353/eam.2021.0021>; Ann Ostendorf, "Racializing American 'Egyptians': Shifting Legal Discourse, 1690s–1860s," *Critical Romani Studies* 2, no. 2 (2019): 42–59 <https://doi.org/10.29098/crs.v2i2.50>.

²⁹ Letters from Layssard to Governor, March 18, March 29 and April 2, 1772, January 2, 1775, leg. 188C, fol. 143–49, Papeles procedentes de Cuba, Archivo general de Indias.

women's intimate matters, was crucial to structuring race throughout European empires. Both granting and limiting intimate options were ways of racializing power. That *Bohémiens* might be granted and make intimate choices other French women did not reveals the entanglements between the ideology and experience of racialization influencing their lives.³⁰ Romani men also married Indigenous women and free women of color in the Louisiana colony. One 1802 account described some of these men, who worked as shipbuilders for the coastal trade, as "lazy" and "with little ambition," but "happy, and liv[ing] perfectly tranquil" lives. The difficulty of this work, so crucial to the colonial enterprise, suggests that the assessment of their character drew from their proximity to Native people or antigypsy stereotypes, rather than from the reality of their labors.³¹

Complaints about how people fraternized might also consider *Bohémiens* in ambiguous racial positions, evidence of the uncertain overlap between racial content and categories that a generative matrix might provoke. When in the winter of 1744 the Governor of Louisiana Pierre Vaudreuil forced the resignation of a white French ensign "for having led a villainous life with Negroes and *Bohémiens*" he revealed his own conceptions about what it meant to be French and white.³² This example also reveals the social choices made by certain white, *Bohémian* and Black colonists: they kept each other's company even when doing so made them suspect. Grouping separate categories together within a white supremacist hierarchy thickened and ensured the continued conceptual and experiential relevance of the "Gypsy veil."

Despite these examples showing *Bohémiens* associating with Native and Black Louisianans, such choices seem to have been the exception. Most Louisiana *Bohémiens* who can be identified seem to have chosen to consort with other *Bohémiens* or non-*Bohémien* white French colonists. The increasing limitations placed on Indigenous people and free people of color motivated *Bohémiens* to distance themselves from an undesirable

³⁰ Marriages, book A, 89, no. 201, and Non-white Marriages, book 1, no. 13, May 1, 1779, St. Louis Cathedral, Archdiocese of New Orleans Archive; Ostendorf, "Louisiana Bohémiens," 681–83; Ann Laura Stoler, *Carnal Knowledge: Race and the Intimate in Colonial Rule* (University of California Press, 2002), 76.

³¹ Louis LeClerc Milfort, *Mémoire; ou Coup-d'Oeil Rapide Sur mes Différens Voyages et mon séjour dans la nation Crèck* (Paris, 1802), 57.

³² Pierre de Rigaud, Marquis de Vaudreuil Papers, 1740–1753, letterbook, February 15, 1744, Huntington Library.

status into which they might conceivably be folded, and to position themselves as white, if they could. One final example from the French Atlantic illustrates this impetus.

The 1743 words dictated by Jean Baptiste “La Chaume” Chevalier, the only known *Bohémien* colonist to have his thoughts regarding race recorded, reveal his nuanced comprehension of the colonial racialized social order and his insecure feelings about his place within it. In 1741, the recently arrived soldier was convicted of deserting and punished with bound labour. After a fight within his abusive household, an enslaved African man was called to tie up La Chaume in preparation for corporal punishment. Realizing his fate, La Chaume stabbed himself because, in his words, “he did not deserve to be mistreated by some blacks.” The inverted racial power of this punishment sent a message La Chaume acutely felt. “To be ordered by a negro” rather than his white superior, as he put it, was an outrageous affront to his sense of how he should be treated. Through his actions and words La Chaume expressed his internalization of the colonial racial order and the assumptions he held about his own place within it. He expected access to privileges of whiteness, which to him meant avoiding punishment by Blacks. In staking this claim La Chaume stabilized race and bound discreet notions of difference more tightly together.³³

ANGLO ATLANTIC

English colonizers also used Romani people – called Egyptians or Gipsies/ Gypsies – as references from the beginning of their imperial project. Two Puritan founders of the Plymouth colony, Edward Winslow and William Bradford, published in 1622 in London an account of the colony’s founding to attract future investment and emigration. Within this, the authors made sense of those they termed “the savages” by describing them as “of the same complexion like our English Gipsies.”³⁴ Years later, William Penn, the founder of the Pennsylvania colony, similarly noted in a 1686 promotional tract distributed throughout England, “The Natives are generally tall, straight, well-built; Of Complexion, Black, but by

³³ Ann Ostendorf, “‘To Get Himself Out of Slavery’: Escape, Justice, and Honor in the Life of a Colonial French Louisiana Bohemian (Gypsy),” *Frühneuzeit-Info* 31 (2020): 140–56.

³⁴ *A Relation or Journall of the beginning and proceedings of the English* (John Bellamie, 1622), 34; *Mourt’s Relation, or Journal of the Plantation at Plymouth*, 1622, ed. Henry Dexter (Boston, 1865), 88.

design, as the Gypsies in England. They grease themselves with Bear's fat clarified, and using no defense against Sun or Weather, their skins must needs be swarthy."³⁵ In this interesting commentary Penn suggests that both groups carry the potential for redemption from their supposed savagery – that is, their complexion was self-imposed and thus might be modified. European civilizing forces – well-dressed and white – could be put to good work on both people. Already a century prior, Tudor laws had criminalized “counterfeit” Egyptians in England, who were accused of darkening their skin as part of their deception. That people falsely presented themselves as members of the early modern Anglo-Romani community was a well-accepted presupposition, and one reinforced through literature and drama.³⁶ When Penn noted seeing Native “women comely, as some Gipsies in England,”³⁷ it was within the context of a complex of well-established antigypsy laws, attitudes and assumptions. That Penn hoped the Lenape might voluntarily convert to English-style living to allow his colony to develop in alignment with his Quaker pacifism might also have motivated his interpretation of the mutability of external markers of difference and the potential to spread European civilization.³⁸

These widely distributed publications ensured broad exposure to such interconnected ways of thinking. Practices of racialization clearly transcended North America, reaching throughout the Anglo-Atlantic world and even beyond.³⁹ And, like the confusion caused in Spain when Indigenous Americans appeared out of context, English observers might similarly be affected. This is expressed in *The Jamaica Lady*, an

³⁵ William Penn, “A Letter from William Penn, Proprietary and Governor of Pennsylvania in America, to the Committee of the Free Society of Traders, 1683,” in *Narratives of Early Pennsylvania, West New Jersey, and Delaware, 1630–1707*, ed. Albert Cook Myers (New York, 1912), 230.

³⁶ Cressy, *Gypsies*, 39–53, 75–77; Dan Cuniffe, “Pretending and Performing Gypsy Identity in Early Modern England, c. 1607–1623” (PhD diss., King's College London, 2023).

³⁷ Frederick Stone, “A Vindication of William Penn,” *The Pennsylvania Magazine of History and Biography* 6, no. 2 (1882): 180.

³⁸ One hundred years later in a nearby location, the German Moravian missionary George Henry Loskiel, living among the Nanticoke people, noted that the “Detached Indian families living among the white people on the banks of rivers . . . are generally a loose set of people, like our *Zigeuner*.” Georg Heinrich Loskiel, *Geschichte der Mission der Evangelischen Brüder unter den Indianern in Nordamerika* (1789), 167; George Henry Loskiel, *History of the Mission of the United Brethren among the Indians in North America*, trans. Christian La Trobe (London, 1794), 130.

³⁹ Cressy, *Gypsies*, 53.

anonymous novel published in 1720 in London. In this, *Holmesia*, the protagonist, “herself a *Creole*, and consequently of a pale yellow Complexion ... [spoke] ... a sort of jargon, being a dialect peculiar to the Natives of that Island, it being partly English and partly Negroish.” In one scene, she questioned a Londoner who “looking on her, thought by her appearance, and her cant, that she was a Gypsy.”⁴⁰ Using skin color and dialect to make and mark group boundaries, while connecting them together, recomposed the matrix that linked and replicated English, Black and Romani people.

Two eighteenth-century German pietist immigrants to British North America again tied the transatlantic racial matrix to Central European antigypsy thought. The first, Johann Bolzius, who led the first group of Salzburger immigrants to Georgia, saw his 1751 description of the region published as a promotional travelogue in Germany. Within this he described how the Natives “who roam through our areas at times are no better than the *Zigeuner* in several parts of Germany, [they] are much devoted to drinking and other vices, steal horses from the pasture, and sometimes shoot oxen and crows for the sale of a piece of meat or the bells hanging around their neck.”⁴¹ Henry Melchior Mühlenberg, a missionary to Pennsylvania, conjoined African Americans and Romani people in a 1774 report from Bolzius’ community. Even Blacks who had become Christian, he warned “retain their savage spite and cunning trickiness like the Gypsies in Europe.”⁴² The content of these behaviorally defined scripts fostered both proximity and distance along a hierarchy of race. By degrading Romani people alongside Indigenous and African Americans commentators constructed and laid claim to their elevated sense of European whiteness.

Actual Romani people who crossed the British Atlantic navigated this cloak of assumptions the best they could. Three members of an Anglo-

⁴⁰ Anonymous, *The Jamaica Lady* (London, 1720), 8, 9, 85.

⁴¹ Klaus G. Loewald, Beverly Starika and Paul S. Taylor, trans. and eds., “Johann Martin Bolzius Answers a Questionnaire on Carolina and Georgia, Part I,” *The William and Mary Quarterly* 14, no. 2 (1957): 220, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1922111>; Klaus G. Loewald, Beverly Starika and Paul S. Taylor, trans. and eds., “Johann Martin Bolzius Answers a Questionnaire on Carolina and Georgia, Part II,” *The William and Mary Quarterly* 15, no. 2 (1958): 245, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1919443>; Samuel Urlsperger, ed., *Der ausführlichen nachrichten von der königlich-gross-britannischen colonie saltzburger emigranten in America erster* (Halle, 1751), 3:979, University of Pennsylvania Library Special Collections.

⁴² *The Journals of Henry Melchior Muhlenberg*, trans. Theodore G. Tappert and John W. Doberstein (Muhlenberg Press, 1945), 2:638.

Romani family, Joseph, William and John Smith had been “transported for their natural lives” to Maryland in 1767 after being found guilty of stealing and killing three lambs. Just weeks after their arrival, they ran away together from the ironworks where they had been sold as seven-year bound laborers. The newspaper advertisement placed to identify and retrieve them began with a racial juxtaposition: “Ran away on Sunday evening . . . Joseph Smith, an old man, a Gypsie, very much resembling a swarthy mulatto in colour.” William, Joseph’s brother was “nearly of the same color” and John, William’s son, “nearly of the same complexion as his father and uncle.” Though using color words to signify has its own Anglophone history, connecting Romani people with those of a particular genealogical descent positioned them rhetorically, conceptually and practically alongside other not quite white people in the colonies. In so doing this author scripted race relationally.⁴³

A generation after the Smiths’ ordeal, white legislators in the neighboring state of Virginia considered Romani people alongside “negroes and mulattoes.” The 1792 repeal of a 1736 statute that had banished Romani people from Virginia, carefully distinguished between Romani and Black people, noting that though “Egyptians or Gypsies” were no longer forbidden in the state, “the migration of free negroes and mulattoes” remained illegal.⁴⁴ Emphasizing Romani peoples’ distinctiveness under the law from free persons of color by the white Virginian legislators shows the shared consideration of the three groups even through the separation of their privileges.

Racializing Romani people relationally occurred in less instrumental ways as British cultural forms moved around the Atlantic. The nature of the matrix accounts for both well-established hegemonic configurations as well as weaker or even dormant possibilities. As such, expressions of the scripts facilitated slippages between forms. This can be illustrated in a reimagining of *Guy Mannering* within a North American context. Walter Scott’s works were hugely popular among a US audience eager to

⁴³ Ann Ostendorf, “Contextualizing American Gypsies: Experiencing Criminality in the Colonial Chesapeake,” *Maryland Historical Magazine* 113 (2018): 192–222; Sharon Block, *Colonial Complexions: Race and Bodies in Eighteenth Century America* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2021), 103–07.

⁴⁴ George Webb, *Office and Authority of a Justice of Peace* (Williamsburg, 1736), 349; St. George Tucker, *Blackstone’s Commentaries: With Notes of Reference to the Constitution and Laws of the Federal Government of the United States and the Commonwealth of Virginia* (Philadelphia, 1803), 33, 165–66.

participate in the Anglo “world republic of letters”⁴⁵ and to connect “beyond the boundaries of nations.”⁴⁶ The central character, Meg Merrilies, a powerful Romani woman, allowed Scott to comment on a plethora of themes. She was a member of a “tribe” who as “the pariahs of Scotland, living like wild Indians among European settlers,” saw their “own customs, habits, and opinions” separate them from “members of the civilised [*sic*] part of the community.”⁴⁷ In the wake of Scott’s popularity, the English writer Barbara Hofland published *The Stolen Boy, an Indian Tale* in New York in 1830. This children’s book presents an American version of *Guy Mannering* by recontextualizing the Romani characters as Native Americans. In the first lines of Hofland’s story, a “Spanish” boy living on the Texas frontier asks his father about the “strangest people that ever were seen who are sitting opposite to the garden. They are not Gipsies, such as we used to see in Spain, but yet they seem to be wanderers like them, and to live out of doors.” The book presents a mash-up of stereotypes that includes references to cannibalism, kidnapping and thievery. Securing and confirming the power of whiteness – and even Europeaness – on the US borderlands worked by grouping and debasing Native and Romani people as part of one whole.⁴⁸

Though this literary linkage suggests the ideological existence of the transatlantic “Gypsy veil,” such concepts never stood alone outside practical application. The lived experiences of both Romani and non-Romani people cycled together with such concepts. As a result, those who engaged with this racial matrix came to expect certain things of Romani Americans. In an article from the Philadelphia *National Gazette* from 1834 (and reprinted elsewhere) the unnamed author explains his knowledge about Romani Americans based on the literary “Gypsy.” He had “seen numbers of a Gang of Gypsies occupying a spot of waste land” near Kinderhook, New York, who “have the features, complexion, and habits characteristic of the Gypsies of writers.”⁴⁹ When another author

⁴⁵ Emily B. Todd, “Establishing Routes for Fiction in the United States: Walter Scott’s Novels and the Early Nineteenth-Century American Publishing Industry,” *Book History* 12 (2009): 102, <https://dx.doi.org/10.1353/bh.0.0016>.

⁴⁶ Andrew Cayton, “The Authority of the Imagination in an Age of Wonder,” *Journal of the Early Republic* 33, no. 1 (2013): 24, <https://dx.doi.org/10.1353/jer.2013.0009>.

⁴⁷ Walter Scott, *Guy Mannering; Or, the Astrologer* (Edinburgh, 1815), 1:103.

⁴⁸ Barbara Hofland, *The Stolen Boy, an Indian Tale* (New York, 1830), 7; Katie Trumpener, *Bardic Nationalism: The Romantic Novel and the British Empire* (Princeton University Press, 1997), 346n50.

⁴⁹ *National Gazette and Literary Register* (Philadelphia), May 19, 1834; *The Family Magazine*, 1834, 2: 86–87.

compared a group of white men bathing with “half tamed Indians” he linked this to “a vivid idea of the Gypsies as represented in the toy books of children.”⁵⁰ The linkages and leakages between fact and fiction condensed the tightly woven transatlantic racial matrix bolstered by the connections Romani people generated in non-Romani people’s minds.

The “Gypsy veil” spun by the transatlantic racial matrix spread across the early US just as subtly as elsewhere. In 1810, New York City mayor De Witt Clinton described in the center of that state “an encampment of Indians manufacturing brooms and baskets These Indians are now the Gypsies of our country.”⁵¹ Newspaper accounts used Romani and Indigenous people to explain the other to readers. Regular recourse to descriptions of housing, mobile livelihood, small-scale trade, clothing and physical features painted two people with one brush.⁵² One author even supposed that due to having so much in common, both being “untamable – one the wild man of civilized countries, and the other of the forest” – they would begin to mingle in the Americas, with Romani people literally replacing Indigenous Americans and settling into their abandoned wigwams.⁵³

Some Native Americans themselves thought about and with Romani people, but in a very different context. In 1828 the *Cherokee Phoenix*, a bilingual English and Tsalagi newspaper, reprinted a short summary of a work of unknown provenance its editors titled “Gypsies in England.” The selection the editors chose tellingly begins by describing an increase in the Anglo-Romani population, a fact that may have been of interest to tribal people aware of predictions of their own decline. The racial perspective expressed must also have resonated. Though described as earning a living “by means of fraud, theft, robbery, or some species of crime” they do so only because “they have actually no alternative For such is the prejudice against them, they cannot procure any respectable occupation.” The sympathetic stance continued, “they are betrayed by their very faces: the countenance of a Gipsy is recognized in England almost as readily as that of a negro. Perhaps the English Gypsies are the only people in the

⁵⁰ *Sunbury American* (Pennsylvania), July 13, 1850.

⁵¹ *The Life and Writings of De Witt Clinton*, ed. William Cambell (New York, 1849), 196.

⁵² For some examples, see *Vermont Watchman and State Journal* (Montpelier), May 6, 1847; *Lower Sandusky Freeman* (Fremont, Ohio), June 16, 1849; *The Republic* (Washington, DC), August 13, 1849; *Southern Sentinel* (Iberville, LA), August 29, 1849; *Jeffersonian Republican* (Stroudsburg, PA), February 21, 1850; *Grand River Times*, (Grand Haven, MI), March 9, 1852.

⁵³ *The Native American* (Washington, DC), March 10, 1838.

world who are born under cruel doom of perdition – Envidable indeed is the condition of the naked savage, compared with that of our Gipsies.”⁵⁴ One wonders if the Cherokee editors and readers might not have felt in the Anglo-Romani circumstance a sense of shared trials and troubles in the face of white attitudes and actions, no matter the racialized assumptions embedded in the narrative.

In considering the position of Romani people, the Cherokee editors added an additional layer to the thickening racial matrix. Playing with the specter of the vanishing Indian connected Native American and Romani experiences in ways that others would also note. This is particularly evident in the popular nineteenth-century travel narrative, a genre that straddled literary and ethnographical writing, and “produced ‘the rest of the world’ for European readerships.”⁵⁵ It also racialized Native, Black and Romani people as part of the “Gypsy veil’s” non-white weft to contrast with the white sensibilities of the writers. By the time these English travelers made their way to North America, they had already encountered Native people through the armchair literature of others. Whether they had personal encounters with actual Romani people, they had certainly encountered them in British literature. These literary encounters primed the touristic expectations of seeing “Gypsy-like” Indians. The “battery of assumptions and predispositions” travel writers brought to this genre replicated expectations in authors and audiences alike.⁵⁶ Of the dozens of examples, a few will suffice.

Augustus John Foster, secretary to the British minister in the United States, commented of one 1806 Chickasaw delegation that they “had very much the appearance of Gypsies, exactly their colour and their lank black hair – a boy in particular had very black eyes.”⁵⁷ One year later, the English writer and painter, John Lambert, while traveling through Canada and the United States promised to “exhibit to the European world” “with fidelity and truth” North America’s “distinguishing features ... in their natural colours.” To do so, he made Indigenous Americans legible through drawing “a great resemblance to the outcast

⁵⁴ *Cherokee Phoenix* (New Echota, GA), September 24, 1828.

⁵⁵ Mary Louise Pratt, *Imperial Eyes: Travel Writing and Transculturation* (Routledge, 1992), 5.

⁵⁶ Jennifer L. Morgan, *Laboring Women: Reproduction and Gender in New World Slavery* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2004), 49.

⁵⁷ Dorothy Wollon and Margaret Kinard, “Notes and Documents: Sir Augustus J. Foster and ‘the Wild Natives of the Woods,’ 1805–1807,” *The William and Mary Quarterly* 9, no. 2 (1952): 206, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1925349>.

race of wandering Gypsies.”⁵⁸ Another English visitor, writing for the *Niles Weekly Register*, compared the lives of English Romani people to “that of the savages, whom I have seen on the borders of the River St. John in New Brunswick, except that the later gain their food by hunting and fishing and the former by theft.”⁵⁹

This practice continued for decades. Richard Longeville Vowell described the South American *Chinganéros* in 1831, as “a peculiar race of wandering Criole Minstrels, whose habits, and even whose appellation, strikingly resemble the *Zingances*, or Eastern Gypsies.” They were good dancers and musicians, he described, as well as fortune tellers and sorcerers.⁶⁰ Similarly, in an account from the shores of Lake Michigan, the Englishman Godfrey Vigne described how his “half Indian and half Canadian” guide took him to “the very darkest part of the forest” to see “an Indian doctress and fortune-teller.” He began curious yet became disappointed that “her manner, her language, and the substance of what she said, differed in no respect from that of a common English Gypsy woman. She shuffled a dirty pack of cards, and told me of the fair lady and the dark lady, the false friend and the true friend, the treasure to be found and the journey to be taken with the same chapter of accidents and unavoidable.”⁶¹ Assuming this encounter did in fact occur, and was not merely a literary embellishment drawn from behind the “Gypsy veil,” one wonders about the genealogy of the fortunes this woman foretold. By midcentury such pieces had proliferated enough to provoke critique: “The traveller who, with poetic fancies respecting the American Indians, first sees one wrapped up in his blanket in a log-hut tavern, can scarcely be more disappointed and mortified than the writer when he first saw a Gypsy encampment.”⁶²

CONCLUSIONS

Though ideas about difference changed over the course of the early modern era in both subtle and dramatic ways, when non-Romani

⁵⁸ John Lambert, *Travels through Canada, and the United States of North America, in the Years 1806, 1807, & 1808* (London, 1813), 1: iv, 358.

⁵⁹ *Niles Weekly Register*, March 25, 1815, 54.

⁶⁰ Richard Longeville Vowell, *Campaigns and Cruises in Venezuela and New Granada* (London, 1831), 2: 324.

⁶¹ Godfrey Vigne, *Six Months in America* (Philadelphia, 1833), 148.

⁶² Alistair Robinson, *Vagrancy in the Victorian Age: Representing the Wandering Poor in Nineteenth-Century Literature and Culture* (Cambridge University Press, 2021), 37.

Europeans thought about people new to them a Romani patina tinged their perception. This “Gypsy veil” helped Jesuit missionaries comprehend, create and control, through analogous comparisons, the Indigenous people they anticipated converting and settling in mission villages. It helped French and Spanish bureaucrats order and regulate their domains. British travelers to the United States saw through the veil to make sense of a new nation at once familiar and strange. At the same time, such practices cohered a sense of Europeaness in response to their Romani neighbors, who had been made familiar outsiders living in their midst. The consistencies shared among the ideas generated during these distinctive histories expose the “Gypsy veil’s” imprint on Atlantic thinking and understanding. Across four centuries and as many continents and empires, non-Romani Europeans contrasted and linked Romani, Indigenous and African-descended people with and to themselves to create their own sense of whiteness, a crucial feature of this veil.

This veil thickened or was perhaps rewoven even more tightly whenever non-Romani Europeans made connections involving Romani people. Such consistent reproduction gave a certain sense of timelessness to the tropes. Each reference to “Gypsies” made in contrast to others and self, reproduced anew, again and again, their unchanging character, which then could be juxtaposed with the progressiveness of European modernity. It also renewed the expectation of, and sometimes even the direct call for, their disappearance, even while their assimilability might be doubted. Alongside this, indeed, as another aspect of it, the “vanishing Indian” and the “civilized European” emerged, grew and stabilized. The restabilized content of these racialized tropes spread throughout the Atlantic world and beyond. That today we emphasize the anti-Blackness, white supremacy and eliminatory logic inherent in imperial Atlantic projects does not mean these concepts and practices ever stood alone. The diverse and changing meanings attached to Europeaness, whiteness, Blackness and Indianness can only be fully understood by uncovering the traces and untangling the connection made by and about Romani people. The transatlantic “Gypsy veil” still covers contemporary thinking; the fabric’s thickness and the weave’s tightness hamper the rending of these binds.

